

SUMFLUX — Waffle House Contest

Judging Criteria

The brief: Each story must involve a waffle house, or the *idea* of a waffle house.

1. Shortlisting

The goal is to narrow the entries down to a manageable shortlist before anyone does detailed scoring.

- **Two reads per story.** Every story is seen by **at least two judges**, not one. Two reads stop a single judge's off-day from sinking a good entry.
- **Use a simple gate here.** For each story, each reader marks **Advance** (deserves full scoring), **Maybe** (on the fence), or **Cut** (no) — plus **one sentence** saying why.
- **Resolve into a shortlist:** two *Advance* → in; two *Cut* → out; any split → quick group look to decide.
- **Target shortlist: 8–10 stories.** That's the set that gets the full weighted scoring below — scored by all judges.

2. The Scoring Matrix

Only shortlisted stories get scored this way. Four criteria, each scored **1–100**, then multiplied by its weight. Weights sum to 100%.

#	Criterion	What we're rewarding	Weight
1	Craft / Writing Quality	Prose, control of language, structure, pacing, an ending that lands	35%
2	Idea & Originality	Freshness of concept, surprise, a take on the brief we haven't seen ten times	30%
3	Brief Fit — Waffle House	How meaningfully the waffle house (literal <i>or</i> as idea/atmosphere/metaphor) is woven in — not just name-dropped	20%
4	Overall Impact	The gut score: did it move you, stay with you, would you publish it?	15%

Weighted total = Σ (score × weight) → a final number out of 100.

Judges only enter a 1–100 for each criterion. Each judge's scorecard works out that judge's weighted total automatically; a separate master tally sheet then averages the judges' totals for the final score — no one does the math by hand.

Worked example — a story scoring 80 craft, 90 idea, 60 brief, 90 impact:

$$(80 \times .35) + (90 \times .30) + (60 \times .20) + (90 \times .15) = 28 + 27 + 12 + 13.5 = 80.5 /$$

Keeping scoring consistent

Anchor the 1–100 scale so a "75" means the same thing to everyone:

Score	Meaning
90–100	Exceptional — publish as-is
70–89	Strong
50–69	Solid but flawed
30–49	Notable problems
1–29	Doesn't work

- **Final score per story = the average of all judges' weighted totals.** No scores are dropped; they're averaged.
- **Brief Fit is a gate as well as a score:** any story scoring **30 or below** on criterion 3 is **disqualified** regardless of its total.

3. Tiebreakers

If two stories finish with the same final score, work down this list until the tie breaks:

1. **Higher Craft score** (criterion 1) — reward the better-written piece.
2. **Higher Idea & Originality score** (criterion 2) — then the more original.
3. **Ranked head-to-head vote.** Each judge ranks the tied stories (1st, 2nd, 3rd...); lowest total ranking wins. A ranked vote can itself end in a tie — in that case the lead/editor casts the deciding vote.